

## A SECOND WORKED EXAMPLE

*THE HIDDEN TRUTH DOESN'T HAVE TO BE DRAMATIC*

RESOURCE · THE EXCAVATION LADDER, LESSON 2

Every worked example so far in this lesson has used the same behavior: Katniss Everdeen, stepping between danger and the people she loves. Self-sacrifice. Physical risk. Life-or-death stakes, every time. That's a clean teaching case — but used on its own, it can leave a false impression: that this process is built for behavior that big and that visible, and that a quieter character might not have a hidden truth worth excavating at all.

They do. This document runs the identical four-stage process — iterate, lock, test against the instances, write the final wording — on a completely different kind of anchor behavior. No one is in physical danger anywhere in this example. That's the point.

### THE ANCHOR BEHAVIOR

Hermione Granger cannot let a task go without over-preparing for it, and she cannot let an error — hers or anyone else's — go uncorrected, even when correcting it costs her socially. Three real instances, the same standard Lesson 1 asked you to hold your own anchor behavior to:

**INSTANCE 1** Before her first term at Hogwarts has properly started, she has already read every set text on the list. Within minutes of meeting Ron on the train, she corrects his spell pronunciation — unprompted, in front of Harry, a total stranger to both of them.

**INSTANCE 2** In her third year, she takes on more coursework than anyone else in her year and uses a Time-Turner to attend overlapping classes, pushing herself to exhaustion to avoid dropping a single subject — not because any of it is required, but because she chose it and won't let herself fall short of it.

**INSTANCE 3** She corrects a professor's factual error mid-lecture, in front of the entire class, fully aware it embarrasses them both and does nothing to help her socially. She does it anyway.

Notice what's already different from Katniss before the questioning even starts: nobody is threatened, nothing is at stake beyond a homework grade and a moment of social awkwardness. If hidden truths only lived under dramatic behavior, this pattern wouldn't have one. Watch the same three rounds find one anyway.

ROUND 1      *"She loves learning. Knowledge matters to her."* True, sincere, and exactly where a single pass of the question stops. This is the conscious justification — and notice it's a virtue, the same tell Red Flag 1 warns about.

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ROUND 2      Ask it again, of that answer: what would it have to mean, for loving learning to require correcting a professor at real social cost, rather than just quietly knowing she was right? *"I need to be right. Being wrong isn't acceptable to me."* Closer — but there's an obvious next question sitting right there: why does being wrong carry that much weight for her specifically?

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ROUND 3      Ask it once more, of that answer, and let it land in her actual circumstances — a Muggle-born witch entering a world that has already told her, structurally and sometimes to her face, that she doesn't fully belong there by blood. *"If I am ever less than perfectly prepared, someone will see that I don't actually belong here."* Ask again from here and nothing new arrives — the chain has hit bedrock.

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*"No one is in danger anywhere in this example. The belief is still load-bearing, still unrecognized by the character who holds it, still carrying real fear underneath it. The stakes changed. The mechanism didn't."*

## THE CAUSAL LOCK

Complete the sentence and read it back: “Because I believe \_\_\_\_, I must \_\_\_\_.”

### LOCKED

*“Because I believe any gap in my knowledge will be read as proof I don't belong here, I must know everything and correct every error, in every room, regardless of how it makes people feel about me.”* There's no version of this character who lets one thing slide to keep the peace. The belief doesn't permit an exception — which is exactly what makes it a lock rather than a preference.

## THE INSTANCE TEST

Run the belief against all three documented instances, the same way you would your own character's:

Instance 1 — correcting a stranger's pronunciation on the train: proving competence on sight, before anyone can form an opinion of her without it. Instance 2 — the Time-Turner course load: pre-empting any future gap before it can exist at all. Instance 3 — correcting the professor: the belief admits no carve-out for authority or social cost, because the fear was never about being polite. It was about being caught short. All three, cleanly, without a bridge or a special case.

## FINAL WORDING CHECK

Could this sentence be pasted onto a different character without becoming false? *“Hermione is a perfectionist who needs to feel smart”* could describe a dozen characters in a dozen books. *“If I am ever less than perfectly prepared, someone will see that I don't actually belong here”* could not — it names a specific fear, tied to a specific circumstance, that belongs to this character and no one else's story.

## WHY THE QUIET VERSION MATTERS

The pattern this example lands on — overworking to pre-empt a gap no one else has actually noticed, unable to internalize competence despite consistent evidence of it — isn't invented for this document. Psychologists Pauline Clance and Suzanne Imes documented it in 1978 in high-achieving individuals as the impostor phenomenon: a persistent, largely unconscious conviction of being a fraud that evidence of real ability doesn't resolve.

### THE IMPOSTOR PHENOMENON

*Clance & Imes, 1978*

A persistent, largely unconscious belief that one's competence is a performance rather than a fact — maintained through visible overworking, an inability to internalize accomplishment as evidence, and a chronic fear of being exposed rather than simply criticized.

That's a real, well-documented psychological pattern sitting quietly underneath a behavior most readers would just call "studious." Nothing about it needed to be dramatic to be true, and nothing about it needed to be dramatic to drive a character's choices in scene after scene.

*The size of the behavior tells you nothing  
about the size of what's underneath it.*

TRUST THE PROCESS, EVEN WHEN THE ANCHOR BEHAVIOR IS SMALL.

### HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

This isn't a required stop in the lesson sequence — Hidden Truth, Therapist's Question, and Red Flags are. Read this one before your coaching session if your own anchor behavior looks more like a habit than an act of heroism, or after, if what your session found feels too small to trust. **It isn't. Run it through all four stages anyway.**

## FURTHER READING

Clance, P. R., & Imes, S. A. (1978). *The Impostor Phenomenon in High Achieving Women: Dynamics and Therapeutic Intervention*.

*Psychotherapy: Theory, Research and Practice*, 15(3), 241–247.

Burns, D. D. (1980). *Feeling Good: The New Mood Therapy*. William Morrow.

Beck, J. S. (2020). *Cognitive Behavior Therapy: Basics and Beyond* (3rd ed.). Guilford Press.